

Installfest

An event sponsored by a local Linux User Group, university or LAN party involving mass installations of computer operating systems or software

Hackfest

Similar to Installfest, this is also sponsored by user groups with emphasis on security issues and reverse engineering of operating systems

Feature



Open-Sourcing India

The concept of free and open source software gained significant ground globally. India is not left behind with several user groups across the country

Arpita Kapoor and Mohit Rangaraju
readersletters@thinkdigit.com

What do Flickr, Facebook, Orkut, Twitter and hundreds of other powerful and popular applications have in common? They all use open source tools. The web has now taken FOSS tools into serious consideration. Various organisations have been set up with a view to create trained man power and increase awareness about FOSS. We thought it would be encouraging to feature organisations / communities in India working for this noble cause. While we covered various open source professionals in the June 2010 issue, this time our focus is on government and student initiatives.

Government initiatives NRC-FOSS

The most influential government initiative for FOSS devel-



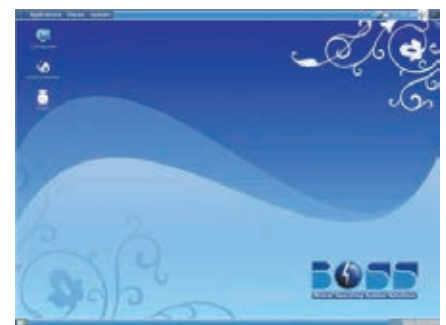
NRCFOSS is a government of India initiative

opment is NRC-FOSS. National Resource Centre for Free and Open Source Software (NRCFOSS) is an initiative by the Department of Information Technology, Ministry of Communications & Information Technology, Government of India which began in April 2005. NRCFOSS was set up in Chennai with the aim of contributing to the growth and development of FOSS in India through research and development, networking, human resource and entrepreneurship development. NRCFOSS today serves as the focal point for all FOSS related initiatives, events and activities in the country.

NRCFOSS is a multi-institutional project coordinated by C-DAC Chennai with support of various institutions including AU-KBC Research Centre (Anna University Chennai, IIT Bombay, IIT Madras and C-DAC Centres in Mumbai, Hyderabad and Delhi.

After NRCFOSS was set up, with joint efforts of C-DAC Chennai and the AU-KBC Research Centre, Anna University, Chennai, major steps were taken by NRCFOSS. Some of them that are worth mentioning include Development of BOSS (Bharat Operating System Software) which is an Indian version of distribution based on Debian, designed to cater to e-governance applications and the Introduction of FOSS Elective Courses and Laboratory classes into the syllabus of Undergraduate Engineering Programs such as Computer Science and Information technology in India. Under this initiative, NRC FOSS facilitated teacher training, textbook content and various student project opportunities.

NRCFOSS-AU Phase-II began in 2009 where in IIT Madras, IIT Bombay and other C-DAC centres joined the project. These institutions carry out research and development on specific FOSS technologies and build compilers and operating systems based on them. They also look into deployment and promotion of FOSS products developed by the community. The emphasis here is on creation and maintenance of FOSS



Bharat Operating System Software in Debian, but Indianised

repositories and databases for educational, scientific and training purposes.

To support the student community in the country, NRCFOSS has a student internship program to help and guide final year students of computer science stream to do their academic projects on open source technologies at NRC-FOSS. With an effort to create trained resources in Free/Open Source Software NRCFOSS has been working with universities and colleges for introducing FOSS into their